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COMPANY DEEP-DIVE

Vice President at Discover Financial Services Praises Omilia's Biometric Security Despite Integration Challenges

DATE PUBLISHED	INTERVIEW DATE	EXPERT PERSPECTIVE	ANALYST PERSPECTIVE	PRIMARY COMPANY
12 Feb 2025	14 Nov 2024	Customer	Investor-Led (Buy-Side)	OMILIA

SMART SUMMARY

Summary

The interview covers the expert's experience evaluating, selecting, and implementing an AI-powered contact center solution, including the rationale for adoption, comparison with other vendors, integration challenges, and the solution's fit for large enterprises.

EXPERT BACKGROUND

- The expert leads customer experience analytics and operations analytics for consumer lending at a major financial institution, with prior experience in sales, marketing, and analytics roles at several large banks, focusing on contact center strategy, efficiency, customer loyalty, and product sales.

EXPERT SENTIMENT

- **The expert is generally positive about the Omilia solution**, rating it an 8 out of 10, citing strong technology, integration, and user interface, but notes the need for ongoing fine-tuning and calibration.
- The expert believes Omilia is particularly well-suited for large enterprises **that prioritize security, fraud prevention,** and customer experience, but expresses openness to reassessing the solution as the market evolves rapidly.
- The expert values the human-like quality of the solution but acknowledges it is not indistinguishable from a real human, which is important for their brand positioning.

TAKEAWAYS

- The decision to adopt Omilia was driven by the need to improve containment rates in the IVR system, enhance compliance and quality monitoring, and address risks associated with remote agents during the COVID-19 period.
- **Omilia was chosen over competitors like Observe**.AI, NICE, Twilio, Genesys, and Five9 due to its integrated biometric voice-based security and advanced agent assist capabilities, which streamline knowledge search and support compliance.
- Implementation of Omilia required significant integration with internal systems and took 6-12 months, with ongoing calibration needed to adapt to varied customer interactions.
- The annual licensing cost for Omilia is between $500,000 and $1 million, with total integration costs reaching several million dollars, but this is considered a small investment relative to the overall technology budget.
- Omilia is seen as better suited for large organizations due to its focus on security and customer experience, but **its sales-oriented conversational capabilities lag behind some competitors**.

AlphaSense Assistant is AI Generated

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Expert Bio

Vice President, Consumer Banking & Lending at Discover Financial Services, a customer of Omilia. Vice President, Consumer Banking & Lending at Discover Financial Services, a customer of Gitlab. The expert is responsible for leading the consumer banking and lending division and has recently done a full evaluation of the AI-based Credit Underwriting Software space for companies like Zest.ai, Decipher, etc. Former National Head of Sales - Direct Consumer Lending at US Bancorp, leaving in December 2022. The expert can speak to being a part of the evaluation and decision-making committee to bring on Gitlab at US Bank. They can also speak to annual spending on Gitlab for

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US Bank as well as Discover (Discover spends about $1m on Gitlab). The expert is a Consumer Financial Services leader and a former strategy consultant with extensive experience leading consumer direct P&L, digital transformation, and customer analytics functions. Proven competencies in developing analytically rigorous approaches to strategy development, customer acquisition, customer retention, and customer loyalty. They have a proven track record of successful capability building & talent development to drive profitable growth and organizational change management.

Interview Transcript

Client 00:00:00

Hey there. Thanks so much for taking the time. I'm happy to start. Look, we got a bunch of questions on how you came to use the tool, the decision making process, what else you looked at, and some of your experience with it. Maybe before we do that, it'd be great just to get a couple of minutes on your background and then your role at Discover.

Expert 00:00:19

Yes. I currently lead what we call the customer experience analytics and more broadly for consumer lending, all the operations analytics within Discover. As part of that role, I work on more broader strategy for contact center.

How do we drive efficiency gains, how do we improve customer experience loyalty? Also, I focus on how do we drive additional product sales and revenue, so very broad mandate in terms of my focus. Prior to that, I have been to various other banks like Wells Fargo, U.S. Bank, HSBC, and so forth in various sales, marketing, analytics type of roles within consumer lending and banking.

Specific to the Omilia, the main rationale for leveraging this type of a capability is mostly driven from the fact that you have a fair amount of calls that are coming in to just do a basic transaction. The technology capable of handling that without having any agent involvement is not only from cost perspective advantages but also from the consistency, compliance and then broadly monitoring and quality assurance perspective.

It gives us far more control, if you will, because in the past we used to have a separate technology and software for analytics, separate capability for monitoring QA and so forth and then separate software for the actual contact center. This allows us to integrate all those pieces together.

Client 00:01:40

That makes sense. Can you talk about how you understood on the use case for Omilia? What were you doing before Omilia and when did you decide to use it?

Expert 00:01:48

What were we doing before that? We have a traditional, what we call, interactive voice response or IVR system. When you call the return number, it says press one for this and press two for this. It's very machine, robotic type of interactive voice response. Many customers don't like to go through that or talk through that. It's very non-emotional, non-human, so to speak.

That's what we had. The main criteria in monitoring the performance of the IVR system is how many customers stay within IVR and close the call or end up transferring to the agent. In the industry jargon, we call it a containment rate. How many customers called into your IVR and remained within IVR? **We had a very low containment, I think, because many customers don't like it or they have a complex question or IVR is just not able to answer, they don't have patience**, many reasons behind it. That was the trigger point for it.

Secondly, during the COVID time, post-2020 and early 2021, many customer service agents started working from home because it is a requirement, so to speak, and there is an expectation. What **that created was a significant risk for the company in terms** of how are we monitoring what is being communicated, how those conversations are going, are they meeting the quality compliance requirements.

We could have potential fraud issues because as the fraud goes up, many of the agents, especially the new ones who are not as experienced, someone can fraudulently call and say, "Hey, I'm a credit card customer and can potentially provide credentials and trick the agent into revealing information that he or she should not be able to or shouldn't be." We don't have a way to monitor that because they're all working from home. These are some of the trigger points, if you will, in terms of what caused it. That's when we started.

At the same time, the technology curve also started improving in terms of the large language models being deployed in various use cases, and the prime use case being the agent conversation. At the same time, **the natural language processing capabilities also started improving**. We had looked at some of the core engine like Nuance or IBM and others who have natural language processing where they convert audio or voice into a text and allow you to do any and all analysis that you wish to do.

That's one option, but that doesn't have all the other capabilities built around it in terms of specific use case based scenario or how do you monitor certain behaviors for quality and compliance perspective. Those natural language processing engines are standalone components.

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The Omilia solution is fully integrated with NLP in it, but gives you far more control, if you will, in terms of how you want to set your use cases and implement it. That's when we started exploring different options and looked at various scenarios.

Client 00:04:40

What time period was this? This is 2022 or something?

Expert 00:04:44

Yes. Late 2022, early 2023.

Client 00:04:47

Got it. At this point, what were the other solutions that you looked at?

Expert 00:04:51

Let's see. We did looked at Observe.AI. That was pretty close actually in terms of should we look at it. We did go through various dimensions. In fact, the solution that **they offer is also very good in terms of the specific use cases** that they have built and developed around revenue generation or pure customer service model or any type of quality assurance compliance.

They have segmented also similar use cases. The biggest difference between them and Omilia was the biometric voice-based screening and security. Many firms now have your voice recorded and used as a basis for recognizing who you are and indirect way to authenticate you. That was the biggest plus in this case, which drove us to use that solution. Then there are other providers of the traditional what we call a CCaaS, which is a contact center as a service software.

Companies like NICE or Twilio or Genesys or Five9, there are many players in that category. Their core bread and butter is the context of the software, but then they also have a GenAI-based jackpot. It's more of a bolt-on, it's not a native. It doesn't have the same capability and the same level of sophistication in the model itself but also the use cases.

Client 00:06:04

Got it. It sounds like Omilia, part of it was the biometric experience security they had built out. Is there anything else they want on? Why did you choose them?

Expert 00:06:13

I think that was one of the core, and the other one, their virtual agent assist solution. This is where the contact center agent is speaking with a customer, and he or she needs some help based on the conversation that is happening. Most companies, what they do is they have some type of indexed database.

Agent can search and query. if the customer asks, for example, say, "I'm traveling to XYZ country and can you look up and see if my credit card will be accepted in that particular city in that country?" Now,. agent may not know the answer right top of the head if somebody says, "I'm traveling to Greece or Turkey or whatnot, and I'm going to be in XYZ City." They'll have to look up those things.

Those databases are very, to say honestly, very clumsy and not as easily searchable because mostly they are homegrown. Agents, sometimes, what they end up doing is put the customer on hold because **they're afraid to keep** them online while they're searching because it may take 30 seconds or it might take them 10 minutes. They may have to ask another agent or they may have to check with their supervisor.

This agent assist capability that they have built, Omilia has a more sophisticated data, both based upon past inquiries and an aggregation of all agent conversations that have happened with different customers. That makes it more relevant and more easy to look up. It also has a capability to add additional content that you want from the company perspective, from policy perspective, or whatever the requirements might be and so forth. That knowledge-base search agent assist capability is another big plus in the case of Omilia.

Client 00:07:53

Got it. It's the search capabilities and then it's the biometric security. I'm curious. There are a few of the very GenAI-first players that we are familiar with, something like that. Poly.AI or Parloa, Decagon is another one, did you talk to any of those kind of players? Do they come up in your evaluations at all?

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Expert 00:08:12

No. This category is so fast-moving in a sense that if you do evaluation today, 30, 60, 90 days from now, there'll be five other new fintech for, I'm sure, category. **It is very volatile in that way,** and it's very difficult to keep up with in terms of who is the latest of latest.

Client 00:08:30

What has been your experience using Omilia? What score do you give it out of ten?

Expert 00:08:35

They're very strong. I would say, it's still early, but in the year, year and a half, I would give them at least eight. The only reason I wouldn't give them 10 is because we don't have enough two, three years of maturity and the data in yet. It does require a lot of fine-tuning in the beginning.

One of the core metrics that we look at is how many tasks the software or the GenAI tool is able to complete without agent involvement. The initial benchmark was can we target 70%, 75%. We are not there yet. That's not by any means an indication of the solution itself. It's just that you have to adjust and tune the model in terms of both what different customers ask for in a different way.

Somebody might say, "I need to replace my credit card." Somebody might say, "I have lost my credit card and can you send me a new on?" Now, both have the same resulting outcome, but they said it differently, and then you add in different accent, different ways to say it. **All these type of things can potentially end up taking you to a wrong task**.

Both agent, the GenAI agent thinks that they are trying to help customer, but **the customer gets frustrated** and then you end up looking for the actual live agent. We are working through those type of fine-tuning and calibration, if you will, but I would still give them eight in terms of the overall solution and the technology.

Another big part we didn't talk about is also the user interface for the platform that allows you to do a lot of configuration and tuning and monitoring as well. That is another big plus in terms of what Omilia has built. As I said now, so many new players are entering this category. One of the question that has come up recently is, in another 12 months or so, should we reassess and make sure that we are still using the best-in-class solution, or is there anybody better?

We might end up doing not necessarily a full RFP but at least do a quick market scan and do a secondary research to see who are the emerging players, what new technology or new features are emerging, and are we still using the best solution?

Client 00:10:43

Got it. How hard would it be to switch providers if you changed out Omilia?

Expert 00:10:47

It's not impossible, but it's a significant investment because you have not only done a lot of integrations because this agent is now connected to your internal contact center software systems, internal data where you're accessing various customer information. Those integrations will have to be redone. They're all API based, so it's not significant, but it's in the 12+ months type of a project that you will have to go through.

Client 00:11:14

How long was the setup process with something like Omilia? How long does it take you guys to get live?

Expert 00:11:19

It's anywhere between six to 12 months because it's not the software requires a lot of setup because it's all cloud based, but you have just so many discrete systems that are connected to your call center. You have your telephony system where the customer calls come through. You have your various chat systems where customers can chat with you, and then you have all your data where current customer information, what is their current balance, all those things.

You have to connect all of those things together. When and if the call gets transferred to the agent, you'll to make sure that you pass all that lineage, what has happened so far so that customer doesn't have to start from zero again live agent doesn't know what has already been communicated with the GenAI agent. How do you pass all that information? What does that user interface look like with the live agent? How do you add that into the queue shop?

It's mostly all tech integration is a one big component. The second one I mentioned very briefly earlier was the calibration and tuning of the model because your use cases might be very different than somebody else. You have to adjust based upon your past customer interaction

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data where customers have different conversation, different journeys, how those journeys are mapped so that the GenAI agent is trained along those lines. It's a six to 12 month setup.

Client 00:12:43

Got it. Makes a bunch of sense.

Expert 00:12:45

The category itself is very dynamic because on one side, what is happening is you have these traditional large capital intense software companies like Avaya, Genesys who are very well established and well entrenched. They are building and developing similar capabilities now. I don't know some of them might acquire or buy solution like this from Omilia or whoever and then integrate and make a more of a fully integrated solution for clients like us.

That's the one way it could go, or you can have a continued best of the breed type of capability that standalone providers like Omilia or Observe.AI and so forth can continue. But longer term, **it's very difficult to sustain** the business just on a standalone basis because most contact centers prefer to buy fully integrated solution from less number of vendors if at all possible because then you have to not worry about all this integration that you have to go through. But that's my personal opinion.

Client 00:13:45

No, that's helpful. Could you explain a little bit roughly how much Omilia cost you guys on an annual basis?

Expert 00:13:51

I think it was several million dollars. That's partly because we had to go through a lot of front-end integration and implementation costs. They are not necessarily the licensing cost paid to Omilia, but that's the total cost that we incurred in integration. I would say that the licensing and the actual dollars to Omilia is in the order of $500,000 to $1 million on an annual run rate basis.

Client 00:14:16

That's really helpful. For you guys, is that a big software spend for Discover? When you look at your budget, is that a big piece or a small piece?

Expert 00:14:25

Contact centers total budget, excluding the headcount just from the technology can be anywhere in the low end seven or eight figure range depending upon how many locations and sites you have and how discrete and fragmented different systems you have.

When I was at Wells, we were spending of the order of tens of millions, but it was a different size and scale there, much smaller footprint. The biggest tech expense, just so you know, is the software like Genesys or Avaya or those, because that's the license fee you pay on a per seat basis. As you scale number of agents, that cost just goes up linearly.

Yeah, but there is a significant bias to invest, and it varies by company, but given that this server is more focused on the customer experience, **they have won J.D. Power** as a number two. Generally, American Express is number one. They have maintained number two position. There is a bias to continue to invest in any type of a software or a capability or even resources from human resource perspective as well, to continue to maintain that because that has a significant impact on your advertising, marketing, customer acquisition and so forth across the blockchain. It's a small investment in that sense.

Client 00:15:39

Makes sense. One theory that we have that I'd love to get your opinion on is that **Omilia seems to already be resonating with very, very big customers**, very large enterprises like yourself or other large franchise institutions, other institutions of all types.

Is it your view that the platform is distinctly well-suited to large enterprises? I don't know if that's because the sales org knows how to sell them to you guys or they've got the right sort of customer support. Is that something that you see, having worked with them, that they are well set up for these large enterprises?

Expert 00:16:14

They are definitely very highly focused and meant, and they have fine-tuned their models for organizations **that care about two things, security fraud and customer experience**. By those two dimensions, you're automatically going to filter out a lot of small firms because while they would like to say that "Yes, we care about customer experience," but when the time comes to invest dollars, they're not going to

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follow through. It automatically defaults into that category of organizations. **Larger organizations are more likely target for fraudulent calls, fraudulent activity** in general. Given that they have built that layer in their software, **it positions them** well for those type of clients.

Client 00:16:57

Right, that makes a lot of sense. I can see that **they're just well-set up to serve all of the fraud stuff**. The other question is one thing we think they're less good at, and you might correct me, versus some of the new solutions we see on the market where it's almost impossible to tell if you're talking to a human or a robot.

With Omilia, it's obvious that you're talking to a robot or to an AI bot. Does that matter for you guys? How important is that relative to all the other things? How important is it sounding natural and like a human versus all the other things that you care about when you're choosing these solutions?

Expert 00:17:34

It is very important. Here's the reason why. We use that in our advertising. When we claim as a main brand positioning that all our customer service is based in the U.S., which is factually true, we do not have any call centers outside of the U.S., period, not even in Philippines. In that sense, we are implying that you are going to talk to a human, and not just any human, but human that is based here in the country where you're calling from. It is a very important and unique position versus many large banks and other institutions who have operations all over the world.

It is, in that way, very important because it is used in variety of advertising, marketing, and other means to position the brand as a more caring for the customer experience and therefore, investing and then spending extra dollars if appropriate for delivering that experience.

Client 00:18:24

Got it. Does Omilia live up to that hype? Is Omilia sufficiently human sounding for you guys?

Expert 00:18:30

Look, it's not going to be because if you are a sophisticated user, you can tell that this is not a natural human. When you dial the HR number, it immediately connects to this natural language voice which used to be previously the IVR robotic voice. Now, it sounds very natural, but I would say 80%+ of the average consumer would not be able to distinguish.

If you look at their typical customer base, they're all mostly, average age is 50+. It fits into their target profile in terms of who they are trying to please. It is better than IVR for sure. I think that as we learn more, we'll be able to also determine whether this is truly making a difference or not. So far, it's tracking well. The only difference, one thing I did not give you is the sales oriented conversations.

This is one area where Omilia has not developed the capability yet, or maybe it's in their pipeline. What I mean by that is we also use contact center agents for revenue generation, not just inbound customer service. Many conversations result from service into sales. Sometimes, we have agents who are making outbound calls for sales. That is the area where some of the other competitors like Observe.AI have built and develop far superior capability.

Client 00:19:45

Got it. I think that brings us to time. This is very helpful. We appreciate you doing this. Hope you have a great rest of your week.

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